skill and courage to vacuum up the secrets of your enemy and survive to fight another day. A single miscalculation can cost hundreds of lives. And this is much more difficult for agents working overseas on long-term assignments because they do not have any cover. They live and work under bogus identities created for a particular operation,' Rita said.

In 2002, the Indian media echoed with whispers that a R&AW spy named Ravindra Kaushik had died in a Pakistani prison. The undercover agent who had managed to infiltrate the Pakistan army before his cover was blown in 1983 had been incarcerated for eighteen years and succumbed to pulmonary tuberculosis in November 2001. A fictional account of his life was published sometime after his death and Bollywood produced a film to highlight the larger than life figure of a superspy. There are various versions of his life floating on publie platforms, each claiming to be authentic. Since there is no file on Kaushik in the R&AW and the MEA has petitions filed by his family in Rajasthan, it would be inappropriate to comment on the authenticity of those papers. But it is a known fact that agents were recruited for low-level operations abroad and Kaushik was perhaps not the only one. According to the R&AW insiders, hundreds of operatives were recruited for tactical operations in the 1980s.

'We have no information of such a person (Kaushik) in our operational record,' said an agency insider. 'I don't think we did this task because the stories seem like fantasy. I would say that any story about Kaushik is completely bogus. The idea behind any low-level operation is to get a continuous flow of information through different routes. It was said that Kaushik was initially paid some money, but after the controversy broke